WHY THE TRIBAL VOTE IS CRUCIAL

THE 47 MPs FROM THE TRIBAL RESERVED SEATS ACROSS INDIA FORM A CRUCIAL CHUNK OF PM MODI'S '400 *PAAR*' CAMPAIGN. WINNING THEIR VOTE MAY NOT BE AS EASY AS IT WAS IN 2019

BY JUMANA SHAH

THE MERCURY WAS UPWARDS OF 40 DEGREES CELSIUS AT THE ELECTION RALLY IN BANSWARA IN SOUTHERN RAJASTHAN in late April and the congregation of tribals was intently observing Prime Minister Narendra Modi. "The Congress could not find one tribal leader for the president's post in 60 years...," the PM asserted, as he launched into what all his BJP-led government had done for the community, including installing Droupadi Murmu in the Rashtrapati Bhavan. The audience, though, didn't look too convinced.

Scores of forest-dwelling and nomadic communities are now bunched under the umbrella of 'tribals' (Adivasis) in the country. They make up 8.6 per cent of India's population, and are custodians of much of the country's natural resources. Traditionally Congress voters, the BJP has been actively wooing these largely backward communities, and with some success, especially in the western and central states. The tribal heartland , though, considers itself distinct in identity and way of life, and continues to defy attempts to merge them into a nebulous mainstream.

Currently, 47 of the 543 Lok Sabha seats are reserved for the STs (scheduled tribes), of which the BJP won an impressive 31 in 2019. To keep things in context, the main opposition Congress party won just four of these seats. In 2024, the saffron party remains the one to beat, even as it grapples with whispers among the tribals about the Constitution being amended to do away with reservations for STs, and implementation of the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) that could erase their distinct identity. The BJP's counterpush has been a rash of welfare schemes, urban development projects in the deep hinterland and, finally, appropriation and highlighting of tribal heroes.

Though tribal communities and settlements can be found in almost every state, the central Indian tribal belt covering a contiguous swathe of southern Rajasthan, the eastern belt of Gujarat running north to south, and adjoining Madhya Pradesh and Maharashtra to the south have a strong BJP presence and similar issues on the ground. To the east, Jharkhand and Odisha with five Lok Sabha seats each reserved for tribals, and Chhattisgarh with four, are also crucial in the saffron scheme of things. The other tribal strongholds are the Northeast and pockets in the southern